elite. For example, visible branding near infrastructure projects funded by IOs or clear messaging about their contributions to public health, education, or disaster relief can help highlight their relevance and positive impact.

Simplifying how IOs communicate is equally important. Using accessible, plain language to explain their work and the advantages of international cooperation can make these organizations more relatable and dismantle the perception that they operate exclusively for elites. By focusing on transparency and storytelling that resonates with people's daily lives, IOs can demonstrate that their efforts are directly aligned with citizens' well-being and prosperity.

In short, by engaging with the public thoughtfully and consistently, IOs can foster goodwill, making it harder for populists to rally opposition and ensuring that multilateralism continues to be valued as a cornerstone of global progress.

BENEFITING LOCAL POPULATIONS

Development banks are increasingly shifting their focus toward fostering local ownership by designing projects and policy reforms that resonate with the priorities of governments and local communities. The UNDP, for instance, frequently partners with local governments to implement initiatives tailored to specific national needs. This approach ensures that development efforts are not only more relevant but also more sustainable by aligning with the aspirations of the communities they serve.

Similarly, the IMF has found ways to directly engage with local communities. Beyond its financial programs, the IMF has occasionally supported charitable endeavors in program countries, demonstrating a commitment to grassroots impact. In one notable instance, the IMF made a significant donation to a local hospital after an on-the-ground staffer identified a critical funding gap.[7] Acts like these not only address immediate needs but also help to humanize IOs, reinforcing the perception that they are invested in the well-being of ordinary citizens rather than catering exclusively to elites.

Aid organizations have also made strides in directly empowering vulnerable populations through targeted programs. For example, the World Bank's Women Entrepreneurs Finance Initiative (We-Fi) offers microloans